

# Written-Response Comprehension — Answer Structures

WR

| NAME  | DATE          | APPLIES TO                                          | USE                                               |
|-------|---------------|-----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Lupin | 9 August 2026 | Latymer · QE Boys'<br>Barnet · Dame Alice<br>Owen's | Every written-answer<br>comprehension<br>question |

Your **Comprehension Operating System** sheet (7 August) covers how to eliminate distractor traps on multiple-choice comprehension — that's the GL/CEM-style paper. This sheet is different: it's for **written-answer** comprehension, where nobody hands you four options and there's no elimination safety net. Latymer's paper is written-response throughout. Dame Alice Owen's and QE Barnet both mix some short written-answer questions into their comprehension sections too. Marks are awarded per distinct point you make, in the words you actually write — so the structure of your answer matters as much as knowing the right idea.

## THE ONE RULE THAT MATTERS MOST

### MARKS-TO-POINTS

**Before you write a single word, look at the marks in brackets.** A question worth 3 marks needs three genuinely distinct points — not one good point said three different ways. A question worth 1 mark needs exactly one clear point, stated plainly, with no padding.

This is the single biggest source of dropped marks in written-response papers: strong readers who understand the passage perfectly but write a beautiful one-idea paragraph for a 4-mark question, and lose three marks they were fully capable of getting.

## ANSWER TEMPLATES, BY QUESTION TYPE

### 1 · Retrieval / short factual

USUALLY 1–2 MARKS · "WHAT DID X DO WHEN...", "WHERE WAS X WHEN..."

State the fact. If the question says "in your own words," you must paraphrase — copying the exact phrase from the text scores zero even if it's the right fact.

*[Fact], because/when [supporting detail from the passage, in your own words].*

## 2 · "In your own words" / paraphrase

USUALLY 2–3 MARKS · ONE MARK PER POINT YOU SUCCESSFULLY REWORD

The no-lifting rule: you cannot reuse three or more consecutive words from the original text and still score that point. Swap the key words for genuine synonyms — don't just rearrange the same words into a different order, that's still lifting.

*Original: "she hesitated, unwilling to admit the mistake" → Your words: "she paused, reluctant to own up to what she'd got wrong"*

## 3 · Explain / Why

USUALLY 2–3 MARKS · POINT–EVIDENCE–EXPLAIN

Never just quote and stop — a quotation with no explanation attached scores the evidence mark at most, not the explain mark.

**Point:** [your point] — **Evidence:** "[short embedded quotation]" — **Explain:** this shows/suggests [why it proves your point].

## 4 · Language / effect analysis

USUALLY 3–4 MARKS · ONE MARK FOR TECHNIQUE, ONE FOR QUOTATION, ONE OR TWO FOR EFFECT

Naming a technique ("the writer uses a metaphor") is worth almost nothing on its own. The marks are in explaining what the specific word choice does to the reader.

*The writer's use of "[word/phrase]" suggests [connotation/image], which creates an impression of [effect] and makes the reader feel/picture [reader response].*

**WATCH FOR:** don't drift into retelling the plot — every sentence in a language-effect answer should be doing analytical work, not summary.

## 5 · Structure / organisation

USUALLY 3–4 MARKS · ORDER-OF-REVEAL, THEN ITS EFFECT

Track what information the writer gives the reader first, second, third — and why that order was chosen rather than a different one.

*The writer withholds/reveals [detail] until [point in the extract]. This has the effect of [suspense/sympathy/surprise/dramatic irony] because the reader [what the reader now knows or feels that they didn't before].*

## 6 · Character / "what do we learn about X"

USUALLY 4–6 MARKS · TWO OR THREE SEPARATE POINT–EVIDENCE–EXPLAIN BLOCKS

Treat this as several mini-answers, not one long paragraph. Each point needs its own piece of evidence — reusing the same quotation for two "different" points only scores once.

*Firstly, [character trait] — shown when "[quote]," which suggests [explain]. In addition, [second, genuinely different trait] — shown when "[quote]," which suggests [explain].*

## 7 · Summary

USUALLY 4–6 MARKS · ONE MARK PER DISTINCT, CORRECT POINT COVERED

Coverage beats elegance. List the separate events/ideas in your own words; order roughly follows the passage but doesn't have to be exact. Don't repeat a point using different phrasing — the examiner is counting distinct ideas, not sentences.

*[Point 1, own words]. [Point 2, own words — must be a genuinely new idea, not a restatement of point 1]. [Point 3, own words]...*

### SENTENCE STARTERS — MEMORISE A HANDFUL

| USE FOR                               | STARTER                                                                    |
|---------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Introducing evidence                  | "This is shown when the writer states..." / "This is reinforced by..."     |
| Explaining effect                     | "This suggests to the reader that..." / "This creates an impression of..." |
| Adding a second point                 | "In addition..." / "Furthermore..." / "This is also seen when..."          |
| Contrasting                           | "In contrast..." / "However, this changes when..."                         |
| Cause and result                      | "As a result..." / "This leads to..." / "Because of this..."               |
| Inference (no direct quote available) | "Although the text doesn't state this directly, we can infer that..."      |

### TIME BUDGET — WRITTEN-ANSWER PAPER

First read of the whole passage, no writing yet ≈ 3 min

Rule of thumb per question ≈ 1 min per mark

A 4-mark question ≈ 4 min, four visible points

Final sweep — check every mark-count is actually met last 3–4 min

### WORKED EXAMPLE

*"Mia had checked the running order twice already, but she checked it a third time anyway, because the alternative was sitting still with the thought that kept circling back: the jingle file on the desk wasn't the one she remembered exporting."*

**Why did Mia check the running order a third time? (2 marks)**

- ✓ **Point 1 (1 mark):** She had a nagging worry/doubt about the jingle file — "the thought that kept circling back."
- ✓ **Point 2 (1 mark):** Checking again was a way of avoiding sitting with that worry — "the alternative was sitting still with the thought."

**What does "circling back" suggest about Mia's state of mind? (2 marks)**

- ✓ **Technique/quote (1 mark):** "circling back" suggests something repetitive, going round and round, like a thought she can't switch off.
- ✓ **Effect (1 mark):** this creates an impression of mounting anxiety rather than a single passing doubt, making the reader sense her unease is building, not settled.